

In the Name of God, the Most benevolent, the Most Compassionate

Rev. Prof. Dr. Ioan Sauca, the Hon. Interim General Secretary of the World Council of Churches

Rev. Dr. David Marshall, The Hon. Program Executive for Muslim-Christian Dialogue at the World Council of Churches

Respected Professors and Scholars

Ladies and Gentlemen

My sincere Greetings to all of you. I am very proud to have once again succeeded in attending this blessed meeting on the occasion of the Silver Jubilee (twenty-fifth anniversary) of the beginning of dialogue and cooperation with our brothers in the World Council of Churches.

At the outset of this webinar, I would like to recall the late Ayatollah Taskhiri, who was one of the founders of these dialogues. Dialogues the impact and development of which we are witnessing today; especially in the field of cooperation and empathy among the followers of different religions. A clear example of this empathy can be seen in the positive response of the world's religious leaders to my letter. Your Excellency's letter, as the Executive Secretary of the World Council of Churches and other Christian Institutions, to the President of the United States, in defense of the Iranian people and opposing the illegitimate and oppressive sanctions, is one of the fruits of the existing empathy, and I once again express my appreciations and gratitude.

I was also very pleased to read the joint statement of the World Council of Churches and the Pontifical Council of Vatican for Interreligious Dialogue entitled "Serving a Wounded World in Interreligious Solidarity: A Christian Call to Reflection and Action During COVID-19 and Beyond" and I found many similarities in it with Islamic teachings.

In these twenty-five years and during the 9 rounds of dialogue we have had, many achievements have been made. During this relatively long period of time, a magnificent and strong structure has been erected, the foundations of which are based on mutual trust, broad commonalities, the will of the two sides to develop mutual understanding, as well as cooperation in different fields. We, too believe that traversing this path is not an easy task and that dialogue is essentially based on the manners and ethics that His Excellency Reverend Sauca mentioned in his speech. As per our religious beliefs, proper listening is the cause of glad tidings by God Almighty and a good question asked is equal to half of knowledge.

Your Excellencies,

The main essence of the divine religions is the call to be a worshipper of God Almighty; an invitation that is based on two fundamental conditions. First, heartfelt belief, and secondly, the manifestation of worshipping God Almighty in the believer's actions. The main and fundamental problem of today's religious believers today is converting beliefs into action. Bad deeds or inaction can both degrade religion to a point that the believer would only a man of religion in name. The spiritual and moral advice of religions is that believing people traverse the path towards perfection. In this essence, there is no difference between Islam and Christianity, and this is the very

foundation of commonalities between the two and it is so strong that it can overcome all the small existing differences.

Extremism and tendency towards violence in the sense of excluding others and excommunicating them have never been accepted in Islam and Christianity. Because the religion that calls for rationality, closes the way to violence first, for, violence arises when rationality goes away. Dialogue is also an important element in exercising rationality and avoiding violence. We have always welcomed dialogue with you in the past years and we believe that it has proved to be useful for both of us, and now that we have put behind the past, I hope that we will go on with these dialogues more purposefully than in the past. Dialogues for finding solutions to the crises and problems facing humanity can provide an effective vision. A vision that would bring humanity closer to peace and would isolate enmity and animosity in the human world. I can visualize that day and I have hope in God's blessings in this regard. We sincerely and always extend our hand in friendship and for cooperation to our friends.

Once again my thanks to you and my friends at the World Council of Churches.

Abouzar Ebrahimi

President,

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